

Australia Daily Brief

Sunday, September 20, 2026

1,684 words · 7 min read

RE: Albanese presses US-China AI pact at Apple HQ · Coalition unveils fuel excise trigger at \$US100 Brent · Marape to UNGA81 · PIF leaders take Pacific agenda to New York · UAE joins Forum as strategic partner

ASX 200

8,731

-0.11%

AUD/USD

0.7121

-0.43%

NZX 50

13,739

+1.17%

NZD/USD

0.5724

-1.51%

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• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Albanese urged Washington and Beijing to agree AI protocols akin to a non-proliferation treaty, breaking with Donald Trump's push against regulation days before he addresses the UN General Assembly in New York.
- 2 Angus Taylor committed a Coalition government to halving fuel excise whenever Brent crude averages \$US100 a barrel over two weeks, funded by \$8 billion from cutting the tobacco excise, a policy Jim Chalmers dismissed.
- 3 Pacific Islands Forum leaders are carrying a joint agenda to UNGA81 as the United Arab Emirates joins the Forum as a strategic partner, and James Marape leaves Papua New Guinea next week for New York.

• TOP STORIES

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Albanese calls for a US-China AI deal as Trump moves against regulation

Anthony Albanese urged the United States and China to strike a deal on artificial intelligence "in the interests of humanity" during a visit to Apple's headquarters in Cupertino, California, en route to New York. He said global rules were needed "because it is moving very quickly, and we need to make sure that humans remain in control", and that he would raise the issue with like-minded leaders at next week's United Nations General Assembly. The prime minister also left the door open to changing Australian copyright law to attract AI investment. **Donald Trump** said he will form an AI force and appoint an AI adviser while warning he will not hinder the industry's growth.

per ABC News: "Albanese at odds with Trump over AI rules, warns humans must be in control" · also SMH

AU-POLITICS

Coalition pledges to halve fuel excise when Brent averages \$US100

Angus Taylor announced a "Fuel Price Shield" that would halve the fuel excise whenever Brent crude averages \$US100 a barrel over a two-week period, cutting about \$15 from the average tank. The Coalition says the measure would be fully funded by \$8 billion generated from its planned cuts to the tobacco excise. Taylor tied the policy to a re-escalation of war in the Middle East pushing pump prices toward \$3 a litre. **Jim Chalmers** dismissed the policy and said the government was not considering future cuts to the fuel excise.

per ABC News: "Coalition vows to cut \$15 off tank of petrol when global prices spike"

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Forum leaders take Pacific agenda to UNGA81

Pacific Islands Forum leaders are pressing for international support on Pacific challenges at the 81st session of the United Nations General Assembly. **James Marape** leaves Papua New Guinea next week for New York, where he will address issues of national, regional, and global importance. Albanese arrives in New York the same week after his California stop.

per Samoa Observer: "PIF leaders push for support on Pacific challenges at UNGA81" · also PNG Post-Courier

• OVERNIGHT

US-AUSTRALIA

Cook calls Australian social media curbs 'world-leading', Albanese says · Reuters

Apple executive chairman **Tim Cook** described Australia's social media restrictions as "world-leading", according to the prime minister, who was shown the company's new child safety features in Cupertino. Australian officials say the parental controls were partly inspired by the country's social media reforms.

TRADE-ECONOMY

RBA's Bullock says inflation fears are materialising · Wall Street Journal

Reserve Bank governor **Michele Bullock** said inflation fears the bank had flagged are now materialising. The remarks land as futures markets price an aggressive tightening cycle, with the ASX 200 closing at 8,731, down 0.11 percent on 18 September.

AU-POLITICS

Intergenerational report projects Australian women living to nearly 90 by 2066 · The Australian

Jim Chalmers says intergenerational report figures projecting Australian women living to nearly 90 by 2066 make the case for health investment. Bloomberg reports the treasurer warning of economic risks as the population ages.

AU-POLITICS

Albanese calls Indigenous child protection crisis a matter for the states · The Australian

The prime minister characterised the Indigenous child protection crisis as a problem for state governments. The framing follows last week's resignations of Northern Territory Aboriginal leaders in protest at CLP policies.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Moscow reports 1,100 Ukrainian drones downed in largest attack on the capital · ABC News

Russia's Ministry of Defence said its forces shot down *1,100* Ukrainian drones across the country, Crimea, and the Black Sea. Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyenin said 450 were destroyed en route to the capital, where an oil refinery and a residential building were hit, as Russia entered the final day of its first wartime parliamentary election.

TRADE-ECONOMY

[Houthi claim drone and missile attacks on Riyadh and Red Sea energy sites](#) · The Australian
Iran-backed Houthi militants in Yemen said they carried out drone and missile attacks on the Saudi capital and on energy sites on the country's Red Sea coast, with a fuel depot burning at Riyadh airport. Brent settled at 99.29 on 18 September, down 8.70 percent, the benchmark the Coalition's new excise policy is pegged to.

• STAT OF THE DAY

1,500

Fijian caregivers to work in Israel over 12 months

Fiji and Israel are finalising the agreement one year after Suva opened its Jerusalem mission, its 14th diplomatic post.

Fiji Sun

• PACIFIC WIRE

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

[Marape to address the 81st UN General Assembly](#)

James Marape leaves Papua New Guinea next week for the 81st session of the United Nations General Assembly in New York, where he will represent the country on national, regional, and global issues.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

[Fiji and Israel finalising deal for 1,500 Fijian caregivers](#)

Fiji and Israel are finalising an agreement to send *1,500* Fijian caregivers to Israel over the next 12 months, with the first group of 25 expected by December 2026. Ambassador **Jesoni Vitusagavulu** outlined the plan as the Jerusalem mission, established on September 17, 2025 and Fiji's 14th diplomatic post, marked its first anniversary. Another 50 students travel to Israel in November for an 11-month agricultural internship.

REGIONAL · PACIFIC ISLAND TIMES

[National Geographic Pristine Seas begins Tokelau marine survey](#)

National Geographic Pristine Seas began an expedition this week surveying biodiversity across reef, mid-ocean, and deepwater sites in Tokelau, at the invitation of the territory's government and in partnership with its Ministry of Climate, Ocean and Resilience. **Paula Faiva**, director of the Ministry of Climate, Oceans and Resilience, said the ocean "underpins our food security through the resources harvested from our lagoon and the vast Pacific Ocean".

SAMOA · SAMOA OBSERVER

[Six by-elections in a year fuel Samoan calls to curb party-hopping](#)

Six by-elections have been held or scheduled since last year's general election, two over bribery and the rest triggered by opposition members switching to the ruling Fa'atuatua i le Atua Samoa ua Tasi, voiding *12 percent* of seats in the 50-member legislature. At an estimated \$120,000 per electorate the cost runs to roughly \$1.5 million, prompting calls for a constitutional amendment.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Petroleum minister rebukes Gulf acting governor over Papua LNG landowners

Minister for Petroleum **Jimmy Maladina** said a statement by the Acting Governor of Gulf Province on landowner identification and participation in the Papua LNG Development Forum was unfortunate and required clarification.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Fiji passes 100,000 monthly visitors for the first time

Fiji recorded 105,791 visitor arrivals in July 2026, the first time it has passed 100,000 in a single month, after a record 986,367 arrivals in 2025. Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Tourism and Civil Aviation **Viliame Gavoka** said the next phase must deliver "value over volume", citing Tourism Fiji's recognition at the 2026 PATA Gold Awards for an AI-powered marketing initiative in China.

• NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

NZ First campaigns on prevention-first health policy

New Zealand First released a "Make NZ Healthy" policy document promising a "bold shift from treating illness to preventing it", citing an "epidemic of chronic illness". Pledges include embedding nutrition in the New Zealand Curriculum and funding hospital trials of intravenous vitamin C around surgery. The general election falls on 7 November 2026.

NZ-POLITICS · BLOOMBERG

New Zealand opposition promises to boost grocery competition

The New Zealand opposition committed to increasing competition in the grocery sector, adding a cost-of-living plank to the campaign seven weeks out from the 7 November vote. The NZX 50 closed at 13,739 on 18 September, up 1.17 percent, while the NZD/USD sat at 0.5724.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

Wellington left with one high-ladder appliance after truck fire

Thorndon Station's 32-metre aerial ladder truck caught fire on Glenmore Street on Saturday evening, leaving the Wellington region with a single high-ladder appliance and the other out of commission "indefinitely". **Clark Townsley**, senior station officer and New Zealand Professional Firefighters Union Wellington president, said he heard a "huge bang" as the appliance passed the Botanical Gardens.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Faith leaders urge Albanese to cool pursuit of Plymouth Brethren

Faith leaders are pressing the prime minister to lower the temperature over Labor's scrutiny of the Plymouth Brethren, a dispute that has drawn in religious groups beyond the church itself.

AU-POLITICS · ABC

Albanese interviewed from California on migration, AI, and the UN

David Speers interviewed the prime minister from California on Insiders, with the panel canvassing migration, housing, AI, digital safety, and the United Nations. Patricia Karvelas hosted Laura Tingle, Charles Croucher, and James Massola.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY · GUARDIAN AUSTRALIA

Albanese rules nothing in on EU associate membership, points to ASEAN and the Forum

Asked whether Australia might follow Canada toward EU associate membership, Albanese said "we're a long way from Europe, of course", and cited relations Canada does not have, naming ASEAN centrality and the Pacific Islands Forum, where he was "just a couple of weeks ago". He said the priority for Europe remains the Australia-EU free trade agreement.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

Auction clearance rates fall on rate-rise fears

Australian home auction clearance rates fell as buyers priced in further monetary tightening. The AFR separately argues a break in the global bond market will manifest as stalled housing value growth over the next decade rather than a sharp fall.

TRADE-ECONOMY · SYDNEY MORNING HERALD

Virginia's data centre county as road map or cautionary tale for Australia

About 70 percent of the world's internet traffic flows through one county in Virginia, and residents there are reconsidering the bargain. Whether it reads as a road map for Australia's data centre build-out or a warning depends on who is asked.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Turkish Airlines locks in non-stop Istanbul flights, eyes Brisbane and Perth

Turkish Airlines has confirmed non-stop Istanbul services to Australia and is examining expansion to Brisbane and Perth, intensifying competition on the Europe route.

• PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

COMMUNIQUE · THE NATIONAL (UAE)

UAE admitted to the Pacific Islands Forum as a strategic partner

The United Arab Emirates has joined the Pacific Islands Forum as a strategic partner, expanding ties across the region. The Forum's 18 members met in Koror from 30 August to 4 September 2026, when the chair passed to Surangel Whipps Jr.

• UPCOMING

SEP
2026

Albanese addresses the 81st UN General Assembly in New York, pressing for global AI rules

Sets whether Australia's push for AI guardrails finds support among middle powers while Washington moves against regulation.

SEP
2026

James Marape departs Papua New Guinea for UNGA81

Puts Pacific Islands Forum priorities in front of the General Assembly alongside Australian and New Zealand delegations.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election, advance voting from 26 October

Determines whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues, and with it Wellington's defence and Pacific settings.

NOV
2026

Fifty Fijian students travel to Israel for an 11-month agricultural internship

Extends Fiji's labour mobility diversification beyond Australia and New Zealand schemes.

DEC
2026

First 25 Fijian caregivers due to arrive in Israel under the 1,500-worker agreement

Tests whether a non-traditional partner can compete with PALM and RSE for Pacific labour supply.

• THE WIRE

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

SYDNEY MORNING HERALD

Can Australia help the UN escape Trump's America?

The Herald argues the United Nations is powerless to protect democracy while its most powerful members veto action against atrocities, and asks what role Australia could play. The piece lands as Albanese heads to UNGA81.

ABC RADIO NATIONAL

Asia Centre's Gomez argues Asia's democracy is being rewired

James Gomez, regional director at Asia Centre, told Sunday Extra that Asia's democracy is being rewired, marking the UN International Day of Democracy on 15 September with an op-ed of that argument.

US-AUSTRALIA

SYDNEY MORNING HERALD

Australia's child online safety fight reaches Silicon Valley

Australia's push to protect children online is registering in Silicon Valley, the Herald reports, as Apple showcases parental controls to the visiting prime minister.

ABC NEWS

White House confiscates press passes from CNN, MS NOW, and Politico

The White House denied entry to reporters from CNN, MS NOW, and Politico after Trump announced a ban, confiscating press passes on Saturday morning. The White House Correspondents' Association said the ban violates First Amendment protections; CNN called it "an illegal assault" on its right to do journalism.

TRADE-ECONOMY

ABC NEWS

Record EV sales outpace Australia's battery recycling capacity

The Federal Chamber of Automotive Industries recorded 27,089 battery electric vehicles sold nationally in August, 24.9 percent of the new vehicle market and the highest monthly total on record. Industry figures say waste management options must scale as the fleet ages.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

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